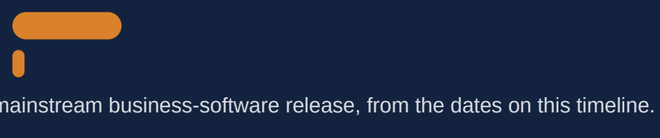
From the Lab to the Sales Floor

Seventy-five years of AI and machine learning, with a second lane that shows when each wave actually reached the business software people use every day. The headline: the lag between a research breakthrough and a feature in a CRM went from decades to months.

Research and technical milestones · **When it reached business tools** · **AI winter (funding and interest collapse)**

IN THE LAB		ON THE SALES FLOOR
Turing asks "Can machines think?" "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" proposes the imitation game, later called the Turing Test. Alan Turing · Turing (1950)	1950	
"Artificial intelligence" gets its name The Dartmouth summer project proposal frames AI as a field of study. McCarthy, Minsky, Rochester, Shannon · McCarthy et al. (1955)	1956	
The perceptron A single artificial neuron that learns weights from examples. The seed of every neural network since. Frank Rosenblatt, Cornell · Rosenblatt (1958)	1958	
"Machine learning" enters the vocabulary A checkers program at IBM improves by playing against itself. Arthur Samuel, IBM · Samuel (1959)	1959	
ELIZA chats back Pattern-matching "therapist" program. People trusted it far more than its rules deserved. Joseph Weizenbaum, MIT · Weizenbaum (1966)	1966	
***Perceptrons* exposes the limits** Shows single-layer networks can't learn simple functions like XOR; neural net funding dries up. Minsky & Papert (1969)	1969	
First AI winter · about 1974–1980 The UK's Lighthill report (1973) judged AI's results far short of its promises; DARPA and British funding were cut. Machines lacked the memory and speed the ideas needed. (Lighthill, 1973; Nilsson, 2010)		
	1980	**First AI that earned money: XCON** A rule-based expert system configured VAX computer orders at Digital Equipment Corporation. Business AI starts as hand-written rules, not learning. DEC / Carnegie Mellon · McDermott (1982)
Backpropagation A practical way to train multi-layer networks, answering the 1969 critique. It waits 25 years for data and hardware. Rumelhart, Hinton & Williams (1986)	1986	
Second AI winter · about 1987–1993 The specialized Lisp-machine market collapsed in 1987 as cheaper desktop computers caught up, and expert systems proved brittle and costly to maintain. (Nilsson, 2010)		
Deep Blue beats Kasparov Brute-force search plus expert-tuned rules wins at chess, and can do nothing else. Narrow AI at its peak. IBM · Campbell et al. (2002)	1997	
	2006	**Cloud computing for rent** Amazon Web Services launches S3 and EC2. Compute becomes a monthly bill instead of a data center. Amazon · Amazon Web Services (2006)
GPUs become general-purpose CUDA lets graphics chips run math for anything, including neural nets. NVIDIA · NVIDIA (2007)	2007	
ImageNet Millions of hand-labeled images give learning algorithms the data they'd been missing. Fei-Fei Li and team · Deng et al. (2009)	2009	
AlexNet: the deep learning moment A GPU-trained network cuts ImageNet top-5 error to 15.3% vs 26.2% for the runner-up. Krizhevsky, Sutskever & Hinton (2012)	2012	
	2013	**Ask your data in plain English** Power BI Q&A lets business users type questions and get charts back. Microsoft · Lardinois (2013)
AlphaGo defeats Lee Sedol Deep networks plus reinforcement learning crack Go, long thought decades away. DeepMind (Google) · Silver et al. (2016)	2016	**Predictions inside the CRM** Salesforce Einstein brings machine learning lead and opportunity scoring to everyday sales users. Salesforce · Salesforce (2016)
"Attention Is All You Need" The transformer architecture: the "T" in GPT and the base of today's language models. Vaswani et al., Google (2017)	2017	
ChatGPT launches Generative AI goes public; a chat window becomes the interface. OpenAI · OpenAI (2022)	2022	
	2023	**Generative AI for CRM** Einstein GPT drafts emails, summaries and code inside Salesforce, about three months after ChatGPT. Salesforce · Salesforce (2023)
	2024	**From answers to agents** Agentforce: AI agents that take actions in business workflows, with human guardrails. Salesforce · Salesforce (2024)

The lag keeps shrinking



Gap between a lab milestone and its first mainstream business-software release, from the dates on this timeline.

What I take from it

Both winters followed promises that ran ahead of data and hardware. The ideas usually came first (backpropagation in 1986), and the payoff waited for ImageNet, GPUs and cloud capacity.

For someone who implements business systems, the shrinking lag is the real story: we no longer get years to prepare the data and the people before a new AI capability shows up in the tools.

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Created by Kavita Shah for AIML-500, Indiana Wesleyan University, November 2026. AI use: Claude (Anthropic) helped research and verify milestone dates, draft card text and lay out this graphic; I chose the business-adoption angle and reviewed every entry against the sources listed.